EASYCUT

CREATOR PLAYBOOK / 05



ENGLISH / US EDITION

Build Shorts People Want to Watch

How to build a repeatable system for Shorts: Demand, Hook, Hold, Payoff, and Share.

AI-generated illustrative creator

36 PAGES / 2026 EDITION

Before You Start

A 'formula' is a framework for experimentation, not a guarantee.

You can't control your views, but you can design a process to increase your chances.

The formula in this book is not a mathematical replica of a platform algorithm. Instead, it's Easy Cut's practical framework for breaking down the five key elements of success and improving them one at a time.

What this book does:
- Scores your ideas
- Helps you write hooks
- Interprets retention curves
- Designs payoff and sharing triggers
- Ties all of these into a repeatable testing process

What this book does NOT do:
- Guarantee specific view counts, recommendations, or monetization approval
- Promise that policies or metric definitions will stay the same

Reference date: 2026-11-01 · Based on official platform guidance and Easy Cut's experimental framework.

Contents

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This playbook is divided into five parts to help you find repeatable patterns, not just one-hit videos:

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The Core Formula

View potential is the product of five elements:

View Potential = Demand × Hook × Hold × Payoff × Share

D - Demand: Is it a topic people want to see right now?
H - Hook: Is there a reason to stop in the first moment?
R - Hold: Does it make viewers want to see the next scene?
P - Payoff: Does it reward viewers for watching to the end?
S - Share: Does it give a reason to share or save?

This is a conceptual model. Use it to identify your weakest element and decide what to experiment with next.

Your Shorts Experiment Map

Half of a viral video is decided before you upload.

Choose your topic and write your hook and conclusion in one sentence before you start editing. That's how you set up a real experiment.

Choose:
Find topics that are already getting reactions and have repeat demand.

Design:
Create anticipation from the first scene to the conclusion.

Learn:
Track not just views, but which sections are weak and which signals are strong.

The Five Levers

Fix your weakest lever first:

1. Demand
2. Hook
3. Hold
4. Payoff
5. Share

If you got impressions but no one stopped: Hook.
If your intro was strong but viewers dropped off in the middle: Hold.
If people watched to the end but didn't share: Payoff or Share.
If all your metrics are weak: Re-examine your topic demand.

If you change everything-subtitles, effects, background music-without knowing your weak point, you'll never know what really drove your results.

How to Use This Book

1. When you're out of ideas
Go to pages 9-13 to score your topics and create a list of 10 candidates.

2. When your viewers drop off early
Go to pages 15-19 and change one element at a time: the hook, the opening shot, or the packaging.

3. When viewers aren’t watching to the end
Go to pages 21-25 to check your retention curve and scene rhythm.

4. When people finish watching but your video isn’t spreading
Go to pages 27-29 to rewrite your rewards, sharing incentives, and calls to action (CTA).

5. When you’re not sure what’s working
Use the experiment chart and 30-day sprint on pages 31-35.

Instead of endlessly tweaking one video, experiment with the same format multiple times to find patterns.

Demand-Driven Topics

Goal of this section:
Before you start editing, choose a reason for viewers to watch.

Remember: Focus on finding your weakest leverage point before chasing views.

Four Topic Pools That Start Views

Problems
Current inconveniences people want solved
Examples: saving time, avoiding mistakes, cutting costs

Desires
Results people want to achieve or possess
Examples: growth, earning money, transformation, recognition

Curiosity
Things that seem familiar but have an uncertain outcome
Examples: comparisons, tests, plot twists, behind-the-scenes

Identity
Signals sent to people like "me"
Examples: profession, tastes, generation, situation

A good topic sits at the intersection of "what you want to say" and "what viewers want to know right now."

Idea Scoring Table

Choose ideas based on a 20-point system instead of gut feeling.

Demand
Are there already questions, searches, or comments about this?
Score: 1-5

Tension
Does the result, difference, or twist fit in one sentence?
Score: 1-5

Evidence
Do you have scenes, numbers, or examples to show directly?
Score: 1-5

Repeatability
Can you make at least 5 videos in the same format?
Score: 1-5

If you score 16 or higher, proceed to production. If you score 12-15, improve your hook. If you score 11 or lower, save it for later.

Adjust the scoring criteria to fit your team and channel, but always compare ideas using the same standard.

Topic Matrix: Trends and Evergreen

Don’t just chase trends-combine them.

Low Repeatability High Repeatability
Low Timeliness → High Timeliness

Archive
Topics that aren’t trendy and are hard to repeat

Search Assets
Frequently asked questions, basic info, how-tos

Rapid Experiments
News, memes, trending reactions

Top Priority
Topics that are both trending now and can be made into a series

Recommended ratio: 60% evergreen, 30% trending, 10% experimental.

Easy Cut Trend Discovery

Turn early signals into topic candidates.

1. Trending Search
Find videos and categories with rapidly increasing engagement.

2. Collect Comment Questions
Gather points where people repeatedly ask or challenge something.

3. AI Highlights
Quickly compare key scenes and possible conclusions.

4. Idea Scoring
Prioritize production order using demand, tension, evidence, and repeatability.

Spot trends early and claim your space with Shorts.

Topic Selection Sheet

Write 10 ideas at once, then select only 3 to produce.

Idea | Demand | Tension | Evidence | Repetition | Total
01 02 03 04 05 06 07 08 09 10
Only create three videos and leave the rest as candidates for next week.

Hooks That Make Viewers Stop

In the very first moments, clearly communicate your topic and promise.

Goal of this section:
Make sure viewers understand the topic and promise right away.

Remember: Before chasing views, identify your weakest leverage point.

Hook Library: Five Starter Hooks

Begin with these five types of hooks:

- Result: 'I finished this in just 10 minutes.'
- Mistake: 'Most people lose views right here.'
- Proof: 'I tried it myself to see if it really works.'
- Comparison: 'It's the same video, but I changed just the first 2 seconds.'
- Twist: 'The problem wasn't editing speed.'

A hook isn't a false promise-it's a sentence that quickly communicates the value your video will deliver.

The First Scene: Three Essentials in 2 Seconds

Show these three things simultaneously in the first 2 seconds:

1. What: The topic of the video-make it visible even without captions.
2. Why: The reason to watch-state the problem, result, or difference in one sentence.
3. Next: A preview-show part of the result, change, or proof in advance.

Your topic and promise should be clear even with the sound off.

Before & After: Sharpening Your Promise

Even with the same topic, the clarity of your promise makes a difference.

BEFORE: 'I'll show you how to make Shorts.'
AFTER: 'How to create 3 Shorts from one YouTube link.'
Change: The target and result are clearer.

BEFORE: 'This feature is really amazing.'
AFTER: 'One button that saves 30 minutes of caption work.'
Change: Shows the change and evidence.

BEFORE: 'You'll find out if you watch to the end.'
AFTER: 'Revealing the first scene that determines your views at the end.'
Change: The result to wait for is specific.

It's more important to clarify what viewers should be curious about than just making them curious.

Visual Hooks: Communicate Instantly

Create visuals that are understood before words:

1. Show the result first: Finished product, before/after comparison, or part of the final score.
2. Show movement first: Hand actions, scene transitions, or object changes.
3. Show the difference first: Big vs. small, success vs. failure, before vs. after.
4. Show evidence first: Actual screen, tools, comments, or measurement scenes.

If a viewer can capture the first frame and immediately see the conflict or result, you have a strong start.

Aligning Hook and Title Promises

The hook and the title must make the same promise.

If the title's promise and the first scene's promise are different, you might get clicks, but viewers won't keep watching.

Title:
Who is it for, and what result do they get?
Example: How office workers can create a Short in 10 minutes

Cover:
Show a clear result or conflict at a glance
Example: 10-Minute Edit / Before vs. After

First Subtitle:
Don't just repeat the title-start proving it
Example: I'll start the timer and try it right now

First Scene:
Show one of: the result, the tools, or the action
Example: The finished vertical video and the editing screen

Designing the Expectation-Reward Gap

PART 03
Structure for Full Viewing

Design the gap between expectation and reward.

HOLD
Goal of this section:
Design the gap between what viewers expect and what they get.

Remember: Before chasing views, find the weakest lever in your video.

Reading the Retention Curve

The answer lies at the points where the curve drops.

Early Drop:
Promise is delayed, or the first scene is unclear.

Mid Rebound:
Potential for rewind, sharing, or heightened interest.

Late Drop:
Conclusion is too late or already predictable.

YouTube's audience retention report lets you see segment-by-segment retention patterns at the video level. Check this after you have enough data.

15-45 Second Scene Map

The shorter the video, the clearer each scene's role must be.

0-2 seconds
Promise
Topic, result, or conflict-immediately

2-7 seconds
Proof
Why should viewers watch? Show it with a scene

7-20 seconds
Development
Condense information, process, or comparisons

20-35 seconds
Transition
New info, twist, or change in flow

35-45 seconds
Reward
Conclusion, result, or next action

Whether your video is 15 or 45 seconds, keep the order: promise - proof - development - transition - reward.

Deletion Check:
Can the next scene be understood without this one?

Transition Check:
Is there new info, a new shot, or a change in flow every 5-8 seconds?

Reward Check:
Does the final scene answer the first promise exactly?

Editing Rhythm for Clarity

Quick cuts aren't as important as quick understanding.

Cut speed does not equal immersion.
The speed at which new information appears creates immersion.

1. Subtitles
Use meaning units rather than full sentences, timed with on-screen speech

2. Visuals
Show the subject, process, or result just before you talk about it

3. Pauses
Pause briefly for important lines; compress simple movements

4. Effects
Use only to highlight new info or transitions

5. BGM
Support the voice and structure, but never distract from understanding

Managing the Expectation Gap

Create expectations, but don't keep delaying the payoff.

Promise
What will viewers learn? State it in the first 2 seconds.

Partial Reward
Give a small answer or proof early, and at intervals throughout.

New Questions
Add reasons to watch the next scene at each transition.

Full Reward
Answer the initial promise exactly in the final scene.

If you just keep saying 'I'll reveal it at the end,' you build fatigue, not anticipation.

Retention Lab: Cut by Drop-Off Points

Don't edit by intuition-cut at the points where viewers drop off.

If you identify the types of scenes where viewers repeatedly lose interest, you can change the structure of your next video.

DROP
The sentence right before a sharp drop-off.

SPIKE
Scenes that viewers repeatedly rewind or replay.

FLAT
Structures where retention is stable.

The goal of analysis is not to explain past videos, but to reduce editing decisions for your next video.

Payoff & Share: Reward and Spread

Return value to viewers who watched until the end and create reasons for your video to be shared.

Goal of this section:
Give clear value to those who watched until the end and create reasons for your content to spread.

Remember: Before chasing views, identify your weakest lever.

Payoff: Deliver Clear Value at the End

Make sure to deliver clear value to those who watched until the end.

1. Information
Practical methods, steps, or checklists that can be applied immediately.

2. Results
Show the finished product, before-and-after changes, or verified outcomes.

3. Emotion
Evoke laughter, empathy, surprise, relief, or catharsis.

4. Judgment
Offer a conclusion after comparison, recommendations, or choices to avoid.

A good conclusion is concise. Just answer the promise made in the opening scene precisely.

Share Triggers: Reasons Beyond Entertainment

Content spreads for more than just entertainment.

Send
The viewer thinks of someone who needs this-like a coworker, beginner, team member, or friend.

Save
The video contains information to reference again later-such as steps, phrases, checklists, or tools.

Comment
Viewers want to add their own experiences or opinions-such as choices, debates, examples, or questions.

Rewatch
Viewers couldn't finish in one go or want to follow along again-like processes, details, actions, or templates.

Before asking viewers to share, your video should create a reason within itself for who should receive it and why.

One CTA: Request Only One Action Per Video

Ask for only one action per video.

Subscribe
Promise a specific topic for the next episode.
Example: Tomorrow, I'll compare 10 hooks.

Save
Remind viewers there's information they'll want to revisit.
Example: Check these 5 things before uploading.

Comment
Ask a simple, easy-to-answer question.
Example: Which opening scene is better, A or B?

Move
Highlight value in your profile, long-form content, or product.
Example: Find all templates in my profile.

A CTA should be the natural next step after the value delivered in your video-not an external demand.

Test & Scale: Change One Variable at a Time

Change one variable and repeat the winning pattern.

Goal of this section:
Change one variable and repeat the patterns that work.

Remember: Before chasing views, identify your weakest lever.

A/B/C Test: Change Only One Variable

Keep only one variable different at a time.

Maintain the same topic, main content, and length, but compare three versions by changing just the first 2 seconds:

A · Result Type
I cut my editing time in half with this method

B · Problem Type
The real reason Shorts editing takes so long

C · Test Type
I tried making a Short in under 10 minutes

Try to match the comparison period and upload conditions as closely as possible.

Look beyond just raw view counts-also check early retention, completion rate, and sharing.

Reuse the sentence structure of the winning hook for your next topic.

Metric Stack: Don’t Judge by Views Alone

Don’t judge your video’s performance by view count alone.

- Plays: How many times did people start watching?
(Signals: impressions, topic, packaging)

- Engaged: Did viewers choose to keep watching?
(Signal: initial entry)

- Retention: Where did viewers stay or drop off?
(Signals: structure, reward)

- Spread: Did people share, save, or comment?
(Signal: value delivered)

- Conversion: Did viewers subscribe, visit your profile, or watch another video?
(Signal: channel value)

Note: As of March 31, 2025, YouTube Shorts views are counted based on play and replay starts. The previous method (Engaged views) remains for reference. Always check the latest metric definitions when comparing videos.

Easy Cut Experiment Loop

Find videos that work, then repeat the winning structure.

Connect the whole process-from spotting trends and analyzing highlights to creating Shorts and tracking results:

- Discovery: Trending and top-viewed videos
- Creation: AI highlights and captions
- Experiment: Three hook versions
- Learning: Record retention and spread

Spot trends and get ahead by making Shorts from them.

30-Day Experiment Sprint

12 topics, 36 hooks, 3 winning patterns

W1: Baseline
- 3 topics
- 9 hooks
- Start your tracking sheet

W2: Hook Experiment
- Apply 3 hook types to your best topic

W3: Retention Experiment
- Fix the first hook, change only the middle structure

W4: Spread Experiment
- Change one thing each: reward, sharing reason, or CTA

The goal isn’t just one viral video-it’s to find three topic, hook, and structure patterns you can reuse next month.

Final Upload Checklist: 12 Points

Before uploading, check these 12 points:

1. The topic taps into a problem, desire, curiosity, or identity.
2. The demand, tension, proof, and repeatability score at least 16 points.
3. The first 2 seconds show the topic, reason to watch, and a preview.
4. The title and opening scene make the same promise.
5. The topic and conflict are clear even with the sound off.
6. Every 5-8 seconds, there's new info, visuals, or progress.
7. There's a small reward in the middle, not just delayed payoff.
8. The final scene directly answers the initial promise.
9. There's a reason to share, save, comment, or rewatch.
10. There's only one CTA, and it's linked to the viewer's reward.
11. Only one variable was changed in this experiment.
12. Record your 2-hour, 24-hour, and 7-day metrics and what you learned.

A viral video might be luck, but increasing your chances is a repeatable system.

Official sources

Open a title to read the official guidance. Recheck current terms before applying or publishing.

YouTube Shorts Getting Started & View Counting

support.google.com

YouTube Key Moments in Audience Retention

support.google.com

YouTube Shorts Analytics Help

support.google.com

YouTube Shorts Creator Workshop

youtube.com

Instagram Insights

facebook.com

Instagram Reels Length

facebook.com

Instagram Reels Specs

facebook.com

FTC Social Media Disclosure Guidance

ftc.gov

US Copyright Fair Use

copyright.gov

Amazon Associates Program

affiliate-program.amazon.com

YouTube official sources as of 2026-11-01:

support.google.com

https://support.google.com/youtube/answer/72851

support.google.com

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